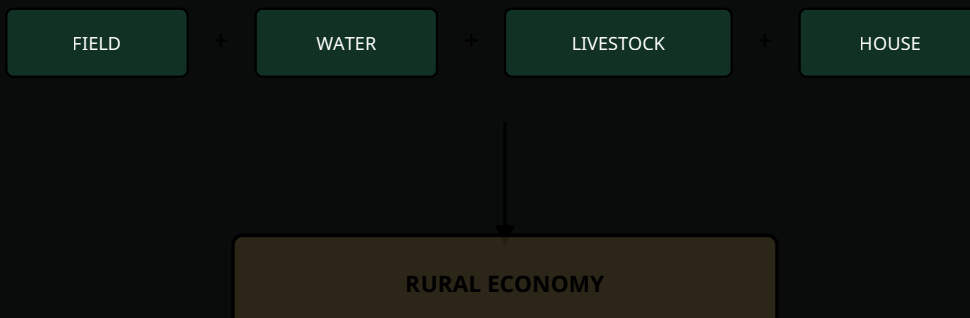


LIVESTOCK & RURAL ECONOMY

“Animals, land, labour and livelihood.”

In a rural economy, wealth is not always stored in a bank. Sometimes it moves on four legs. A cow can provide milk. A goat can become a source of cash. A sheep can become food or an asset. An animal can also represent years of household labour and care. For many rural families, livestock is therefore more than agriculture. It is part of the household economy.

Building upon the agricultural foundations established in Page 47, livestock raising has historically formed a vital component of the rural livelihood system in Orakzai. In a region where arable land is finite, animals serve as a mobile biological asset, a buffer against environmental risks, and a primary source of nutritional and financial security.¹³



“Synthesis of land, water, livestock, and household into the Orakzai rural economy.”

THE LIVESTOCK SYSTEM

Livestock in Orakzai operates as a circular system integrated with crop production. Animals convert crop residues and common-land grazing into high-value products like milk and meat, while simultaneously providing organic manure to maintain the fertility of valley soils. This synergy is fundamental to the resilience of mountain households.³⁶



“Livestock value chain from land and feed to care, product, and market integration.”

MAIN LIVESTOCK CATEGORIES

Agricultural census data identifies **goats** as the most numerous livestock category in Orakzai, reflecting their adaptability to steep terrain and diverse grazing. **Cattle** and **sheep** also hold significant roles, providing milk, meat, and wool. While historical records show a presence of buffalo and camels, their numbers have shifted alongside modern transport and agricultural practices.¹²

ANIMAL	PRIMARY FUNCTION	ECONOMIC ROLE	STATUS (HISTORICAL VS. RECENT)
Goats	Meat & Sale	High liquidity cash source	Dominant population (approx. 107k+) [2]
Cattle	Milk & Reproduction	Stable household asset	Significant presence (approx. 64k+) [2]
Sheep	Meat & Wool	Asset & production	Stable population (approx. 52k+) [2]
Asses & Mules	Rural Transport	Logistical support	Declining with modernization [1] [2]

ORAKZAI LIVESTOCK — HISTORICAL BASELINE

Based on Orakzai Agency — Livestock Census 2006. Historical census data; not a current population estimate.

111,849

GOATS

68,671

CATTLE

49,951

SHEEP

13,450

BUFFALO

LIVESTOCK AS AN ASSET

In the Orakzai rural economy, a household animal is more than a biological entity; it is a physical asset. Animals can be consumed for nutrition, sold for cash, bred for expansion, or

exchanged for other goods. This "biological asset" model provides families with a tangible way to store value and manage financial needs outside of formal banking systems.³⁴



“The triple-role of livestock as asset, food, and capital.”

WHAT WE KNOW — AND WHAT WE DO NOT

Current publicly accessible district-level livestock statistics for Orakzai are limited; historical census figures therefore provide context rather than a current population estimate. Official 2024 agricultural census data provides livestock statistics for Khyber Pakhtunkhwa at the provincial level, while district-level historical data for Orakzai remains the primary baseline for specific tribal analysis.

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

There is a quiet dignity in the way a family cares for its herd. To an outsider, it is merely livestock. To an Orakzai household, it is the result of years of early mornings and cold winters. When we look at our animals, we see the labour of our mothers who milked them and the strength of our brothers who herded them across the ridges. Wealth in our mountains is not measured by what is hidden in a vault, but by the life that thrives under our care.

“The herd is the moving legacy of the household.”

